COMPTIA SECURITY+ SY0-701 | DOMAIN 5 · SECURITY PROGRAM MANAGEMENT AND OVERSIGHT (20%)

Security+ 5.5 · Penetration Tests

Mestre CyberSec · **Lesson 5.5 — Penetration Tests** (5:29) · Assistir Vídeo no YouTube ↗ · Treino Interativo: edusouzamarques.github.io/cybersec

Executive Lesson Summary: Pentest complementa auditoria: perspectives (external/internal/fully trusted); technique: reconnaissance, OSINT, social engineering; responsible disclosure. Mais técnica do que auditoria, menos formal.

💡 Key Exam Highlights & Critical Concepts

- Pentest: EVIDENCIA exploitation real — complementa a auditoria formal
- Perspectives: external (de fora), internal (de dentro), full credencial

🎯 Exam Tips & Typical CompTIA Scenarios

- 'external perspective attempting to exploit from outside'=external pentest

🚨 Beyond the Video: Official Exam Concepts, Protocols & Traps (Section 5.5 — Penetration Tests)

Why is this advanced coverage required for SY0-701?: Video lectures provide foundational concepts, but CompTIA tests practical engineering judgment and requires deep familiarity with the following protocols, acronyms, and operational nuances in this domain:

• Penetration Test (Pentest)
An authorized, active attempt to exploit real vulnerabilities in a system, providing evidence of actual risk rather than just a list of findings. It complements a formal audit by demonstrating whether a vulnerability is truly exploitable.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Trigger: 'active exploitation' or 'evidence of exploitability' → Pentest, NOT a vulnerability scan or audit. Pentest is more technical and less formal than a compliance audit.*

• External Perspective (N/A)
A penetration test performed from outside the organization's network with no inside knowledge or credentials, simulating an anonymous attacker on the internet.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Trigger: 'attempting to exploit from outside the network' or 'no internal knowledge' → External perspective. Do not confuse with 'unknown environment' (which describes knowledge, not location).*

• Internal Perspective (N/A)
A penetration test conducted from within the trusted network (or simulating an insider/malicious employee) to identify risks that an on-site attacker could exploit.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Trigger: 'insider threat simulation' or 'attacker already inside the network' → Internal perspective. Remember: physical access and rogue employee scenarios map here.*

• Full Credential (N/A)
A pentest scope in which the tester is given valid user/admin credentials, simulating an authenticated user or fully trusted insider to find post-authentication flaws.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Trigger: 'fully trusted' or 'provided valid login' → Full credential test. This is NOT the same as 'known environment'; credentials ≠ source code/network knowledge.*

• Reconnaissance
The information-gathering stage of a pentest, used to map the target before active exploitation. Includes both passive OSINT and active probing of systems and services.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Trigger: 'gathering information about the target before exploitation' → Reconnaissance. Distinguish passive (no direct contact) from active (touching the target) recon.*

• Open Source Intelligence (OSINT)

Passive reconnaissance using publicly available sources (search engines, social media, DNS records, Shodan) to gather information about a target without directly interacting with it.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Trigger: 'publicly available sources' or 'passive information gathering' → OSINT. The key word 'passive' means no packets are sent to the target.*

• Social Engineering (SE)

Pentest technique that targets human factors (phishing, vishing, pretexting, tailgating) to bypass technical controls. Often the path of least resistance into an organization.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Trigger: 'exploiting people instead of systems' or 'human vulnerability' → Social engineering. Phishing/vishing/pretexting/impersonation all belong here, NOT to technical exploits.*

• Responsible Disclosure (N/A)

The process by which a pentester or researcher privately reports discovered vulnerabilities to the organization first, giving it time to remediate before any public release.

⚠️ ***Exam Trap:*** *Trigger: 'reporting vulnerabilities privately to the vendor' or 'coordinated disclosure' → Responsible disclosure. Distinguish from 'full disclosure' (public immediately) — exam questions favor responsible disclosure as the ethical choice.*

✅ Authentic Practice Questions (10 Real Exam Scenarios)

Scenario-based exam questions. Complete explanations and distractor analysis are provided in the answer key below.

QUESTION 1 · EXAM SCENARIO

An e-commerce company hires a security firm to assess its internet-facing web application and mail gateway. The testers are not given credentials, internal network access, or documentation, and they launch attacks from cloud-hosted systems to mimic an anonymous adversary. Which penetration testing perspective is being used?

A) External perspective

B) Internal perspective

C) Full credential perspective

D) Physical perspective

QUESTION 2 · EXAM SCENARIO

A financial institution wants to know what a malicious contractor could do after plugging a laptop into an unused conference room Ethernet port. The tester is given a network drop but no user accounts or system documentation. Which perspective does this represent?

A) External perspective

B) Internal perspective

C) Full credential perspective

D) Supply chain perspective

QUESTION 3 · EXAM SCENARIO

During an engagement, the client provides the tester with a standard employee user account, a corporate laptop, and normal building access. The goal is to determine whether the account can be abused to reach sensitive systems. Which perspective is this?

A) External perspective

B) Internal perspective

C) Full credential perspective

D) Passive reconnaissance

QUESTION 4 · EXAM SCENARIO

Before any active scanning, a tester reviews the target's public DNS records, technology job postings, vendor case studies, and employee social media profiles to identify technologies and personnel. Which technique is being used?

A) OSINT

B) Vulnerability scanning

C) Password spraying

D) Packet capture

QUESTION 5 · EXAM SCENARIO

An attacker calls the service desk and claims to be a traveling executive who lost a multi-factor authentication token. The attacker uses details from a recent company press release to sound convincing and asks for the token to be reset. Which penetration testing technique is illustrated?

A) Open source intelligence

B) Social engineering

C) Network enumeration

D) Vulnerability exploitation

QUESTION 6 · EXAM SCENARIO

After a penetration test, the tester discovers a critical remote code execution flaw in a vendor's product used by many customers. The client confirms it is not their custom code. What should the tester do next?

A) Publish the exploit on a public forum immediately to force a fix

B) Notify the vendor privately and allow a reasonable remediation period before disclosure

C) Report it only to the client and take no further action

D) Add the exploit to the final client report but do not contact the vendor

QUESTION 7 · EXAM SCENARIO

A company completed a formal compliance audit that identified missing security patches on servers. The CISO wants to demonstrate whether an attacker could actually exploit those missing patches to compromise the domain. Which activity best meets this objective?

A) Another compliance audit

B) Penetration test

C) Risk assessment

D) Vulnerability scan

QUESTION 8 · EXAM SCENARIO

A tester is hired to assess a web application. The tester first queries public WHOIS records, certificate transparency logs, and search engines to learn about the organization's infrastructure without sending traffic directly to the target. Which phase of a penetration test is this?

A) Reconnaissance

B) Exploitation

C) Reporting

D) Post-exploitation

QUESTION 9 · EXAM SCENARIO

An organization wants the most realistic test of its defenses against an intruder who has already obtained valid credentials for a low-privileged help desk account and knows the internal network layout. The testers are given those credentials, network diagrams, and source code. Which perspective is being used?

A) External perspective

B) Internal perspective

C) Full credential perspective

D) Black-box perspective

QUESTION 10 · EXAM SCENARIO

A penetration tester is authorized to test a client's public web application. During testing, the tester finds a vulnerability that exposes customer data. The client asks the tester to immediately post details to a public mailing list so other companies can check their systems. What should the tester recommend?

A) Coordinate private disclosure with the client, allow remediation, then publish sanitized details if appropriate

B) Post the full exploit and customer data immediately because the client gave permission

C) Notify the public before notifying the client so users can protect themselves

D) Remove the finding from the report and keep the exploit private indefinitely

ANSWER KEY & COMPREHENSIVE DISTRACTOR EXPLANATIONS

Question 1: Option A — External perspective

External perspective simulates an attacker outside the organization's perimeter. The testers start from the internet, have no valid credentials or internal access, and target externally exposed services. Internal perspective would begin inside the network; full credential would provide accounts and documentation; physical perspective focuses on physical controls.

Question 2: Option B — Internal perspective

Internal perspective simulates an attacker or insider who already has network access from inside the organization. Because the tester has a network drop but no valid accounts or documentation, this is an internal, uncredentialed test. External would start from the internet; full credential would include accounts; supply chain is not one of the standard perspectives.

Question 3: Option C — Full credential perspective

Full credential perspective, also called fully trusted or credentialed testing, provides valid credentials and often detailed access to test insider privilege abuse and lateral movement. External testing starts from outside; internal testing may have network access but no credentials; passive reconnaissance is a technique, not a perspective.

Question 4: Option A — OSINT

OSINT (Open Source Intelligence) is the collection and analysis of publicly available information. Reviewing DNS records, job postings, case studies, and social media helps build a target profile before active testing. Vulnerability scanning, password spraying, and packet capture are active or traffic-based techniques.

Question 5: Option B — Social engineering

Social engineering manipulates people into bypassing security controls. The attacker uses a voice call and a believable pretext to persuade the help desk to reset MFA. OSINT may support the pretext, but the technique used to gain access is social engineering. Network enumeration and vulnerability exploitation target systems, not people.

Question 6: Option B — Notify the vendor privately and allow a reasonable remediation period before disclosure

Responsible disclosure means privately notifying the affected vendor, giving a reasonable remediation window, and coordinating any public release. Publishing immediately can expose customers; reporting only to the client may leave other users at risk; omitting vendor contact fails to address the product flaw.

Question 7: Option B — Penetration test

A penetration test is more technical than an audit and attempts to exploit weaknesses to demonstrate real impact. An audit is more formal and checks compliance; a risk assessment evaluates likelihood and impact; a vulnerability scan identifies missing patches but does not usually exploit them.

Question 8: Option A — Reconnaissance

Reconnaissance is the information-gathering phase before exploitation. Using WHOIS, certificate transparency logs, and search engines without directly touching the target is passive reconnaissance/OSINT. Exploitation involves attacks; reporting documents findings; post-exploitation occurs after a compromise.

Question 9: Option C — Full credential perspective

Full credential perspective provides valid credentials and often detailed knowledge such as diagrams and source code. This simulates a trusted insider or an attacker who has already compromised an account. Internal perspective may begin inside the network but does not necessarily include credentials; external starts outside; black-box provides little or no knowledge.

Question 10: Option A — Coordinate private disclosure with the client, allow remediation, then publish sanitized details if appropriate

Responsible disclosure requires reporting the issue privately, giving the affected party time to remediate, and coordinating any public release. Immediate public posting can expose customer data and increase risk. The tester should recommend coordinated disclosure rather than unauthorized or harmful release.